The Truman Doctrine

President Harry S. Truman · Address to Joint Session of Congress · March 12, 1947

Source: Harry S. Truman, Address to Congress (March 12, 1947), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

When the British announced in February 1947 that they could no longer afford to support anti-communist governments in Greece and Turkey, Truman asked Congress for $400 million to fill the gap. To get the bill through, he framed the request as a broad new doctrine: the U.S. would 'support free peoples' resisting subjugation. The Truman Doctrine inaugurated the policy of 'containment' that would shape U.S. foreign policy for the next 40+ years.

Connect: Truman framed U.S. aid as protecting 'free peoples' from 'subjugation.' Compare his framing to Wilson's 'make the world safe for democracy' (Class 39). Are these the same argument, 30 years apart?

Key Passages

Two ways of life

> At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority … The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority. It relies upon terror and oppression, a controlled press and radio; fixed elections, and the suppression of personal freedoms.

The Doctrine

> I believe that it must be the policy of the United States to support free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures. I believe that we must assist free peoples to work out their own destinies in their own way. I believe that our help should be primarily through economic and financial aid which is essential to economic stability and orderly political processes.

Stakes

> Should we fail to aid Greece and Turkey in this fateful hour, the effect will be far reaching to the West as well as to the East. We must take immediate and resolute action. I therefore ask the Congress to provide authority for assistance to Greece and Turkey in the amount of $400,000,000 for the period ending June 30, 1948.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Early Cold War: Britain could no longer aid Greece (civil war with communists) or Turkey (Soviet pressure), and the U.S.-Soviet wartime alliance had collapsed.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, which had to approve $400 million in aid, and the American public, which had to be convinced to accept global commitments.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Harry Truman, a Democrat who saw Soviet communism as a threat to freedom and wanted to contain it.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — identify & explain a Cold War policy: Identify ONE specific Cold War policy that grew from the Truman Doctrine.
2. Why did Truman frame a narrow Greece-Turkey aid request as a global doctrine?
3. Identify ONE later application of the Truman Doctrine (Korea, Vietnam, Cuba, Afghanistan).

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> Asking Congress to aid Greece and Turkey against communist pressure, Truman committed the United States to containing the spread of communism — the guiding principle of American Cold War foreign policy.

The request: Greece and Turkey

The gravity of the situation which confronts the world today necessitates my appearance before a joint session of the Congress. The foreign policy and the national security of this country are involved. One aspect of the present situation, which I wish to present to you at this time for your consideration and decision, concerns Greece and Turkey.

[. . .]

The very existence of the Greek state is today threatened by the terrorist activities of several thousand armed men, led by Communists, who defy the government's authority at a number of points, particularly along the northern boundaries. . . . The British Government, which has been helping Greece, can give no further financial or economic aid after March 31. Great Britain finds itself under the necessity of reducing or liquidating its commitments in several parts of the world, including Greece. . . . As in the case of Greece, if Turkey is to have the assistance it needs, the United States must supply it. We are the only country able to provide that help.

[. . .]

The broad implications

One of the primary objectives of the foreign policy of the United States is the creation of conditions in which we and other nations will be able to work out a way of life free from coercion. This was a fundamental issue in the war with Germany and Japan. Our victory was won over countries which sought to impose their will, and their way of life, upon other nations. . . . We shall not realize our objectives, however, unless we are willing to help free peoples to maintain their free institutions and their national integrity against aggressive movements that seek to impose upon them totalitarian regimes. This is no more than a frank recognition that totalitarian regimes imposed on free peoples, by direct or indirect aggression, undermine the foundations of international peace and hence the security of the United States.

[. . .]

Two ways of life

At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority, and is distinguished by free institutions, representative government, free elections, guarantees of individual liberty, freedom of speech and religion, and freedom from political oppression. The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority. It relies upon terror and oppression, a controlled press and radio; fixed elections, and the suppression of personal freedoms.

The Doctrine

I believe that it must be the policy of the United States to support free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures. I believe that we must assist free peoples to work out their own destinies in their own way. I believe that our help should be primarily through economic and financial aid which is essential to economic stability and orderly political processes.

[. . .]

Stakes

It is necessary only to glance at a map to realize that the survival and integrity of the Greek nation are of grave importance in a much wider situation. If Greece should fall under the control of an armed minority, the effect upon its neighbor, Turkey, would be immediate and serious. Confusion and disorder might well spread throughout the entire Middle East. . . . Should we fail to aid Greece and Turkey in this fateful hour, the effect will be far reaching to the West as well as to the East. We must take immediate and resolute action. I therefore ask the Congress to provide authority for assistance to Greece and Turkey in the amount of $400,000,000 for the period ending June 30, 1948.

[. . .]

The seeds of totalitarian regimes are nurtured by misery and want. They spread and grow in the evil soil of poverty and strife. They reach their full growth when the hope of a people for a better life has died. We must keep that hope alive. The free peoples of the world look to us for support in maintaining their freedoms. If we falter in our leadership, we may endanger the peace of the world — and we shall surely endanger the welfare of our own nation. Great responsibilities have been placed upon us by the swift movement of events. I am confident that the Congress will face these responsibilities squarely.

Words to know

liquidating its commitments — ending its promises of support and pulling out

coercion — force or threats used to control people

totalitarian regimes — governments that control every part of life and allow no opposition

subjugation — being conquered and brought under another's control

integrity — survival as a whole, independent nation

falter — hesitate or weaken